

See also: Early legal codes 18–19 ■ The *Arthashastra* and the *Manusmriti* 35 ■ The Mishnah and the Talmud 38–41
■ The origins of canon law 42–47 ■ The Koran 54–57



This 17th-century painting by French portrait artist Philippe de Champaigne, entitled “Moses with the Ten Commandments,” shows the inscriptions on two tablets of stone.

Mosaic law was perceived as part of a covenant, a formal agreement, between God and the Israelites. It was believed that God promised to protect the Israelites and give them the land of Canaan if they obeyed his laws. According to Exodus 19:5, God said, “Now if you obey me fully and keep my covenant, then out of all nations you will be my treasured possession.”

Authors of the Torah

The books of the Torah, written in Hebrew, were thought to have been set down by Moses himself. But, from the 18th century, scholars developed a historical approach to reading the Bible, which appeared

to show that the stories had been shaped over time by many authors using different vocabulary and styles. The text includes footnotes inserted by later generations to explain ancient place names and point out evidence for events still visible “to this very day.”

Scholars in 19th-century Germany identified four types of source material in the Torah. They were termed E, J, D, and P (Elohism, Jahwism, Deuteronomism, and Priestly), with the earliest material (most of Genesis, much of Exodus, and some elements of Numbers) thought to come from E and J. Source E describes the traditions of the northern tribes and refers to God by the title “Elohim” (“god”). Source J pertains mainly to the southern Israelite tribe of Judah and refers to God by his four-letter name YHWH, assumed to be pronounced “Yahweh.” »

as well as many detailed laws covering moral behavior, religious worship, and every part of daily life. The most important Commandment was the first: “You shall have no other gods before me.” The Israelites spent another 40 years in the desert before reaching Canaan, and Moses himself died within sight of it.

The five books of the Torah

Genesis

Creation and the Israelites’ ancestry from Adam and Eve.

Exodus

Escape from Egypt and laws, including the Ten Commandments.

Leviticus

Laws on sacrifice, priesthood, and ritual purity.

Numbers

The Israelites’ 40 years in the desert and a census of the tribes.

Deuteronomy

Laws on worship, crime, and punishment, delivered by Moses before his death.